



Economics

China Macro

Date

11 May 2026

Trade Momentum Continues in April

China exports grew by 14.1% YoY in April, exceeding the market's expectation of 8% and our estimate of 10%. This strong performance was primarily driven by continued robust demand from emerging markets, AI-related products, autos and parts, and HALO assets. Most notably, export growth of computers and semiconductors surged further to 73% YoY in April from 50% in Q1. These developments confirm our previous view that ["AHEAD" factors](#) will continue to support China's export growth over a longer period.

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Imports increased more rapidly, by 25.3% YoY, accelerating from Q1 (23.6%) and beating expectations again (consensus: 14.7%, DB: 18%). In the first four months, import growth on average outpaced export growth by 8 percentage points (seasonally adjusted). We attribute this stronger-than-expected import performance to three key factors:

- **Raw materials and equipment for export production:** The largest drivers of import growth in Q1 were AI-related products, primary products, metals, machinery, and chemicals. This aligns strongly with China's export-growth trends, indicating a significant demand for inputs to fuel export manufacturing.
- **Rising overseas prices:** For major imported goods with disclosed data, import-price growth in April broadly exceeded that of Q1. This was most evident in petroleum, where prices surged by 42% YoY in April, a dramatic 50ppt increase from Q1. Our estimates suggest that the contribution of price to total import value rose from -13ppt in Q1 to 33ppt in April.
- **Potential recovery in domestic demand:** Industrial inventories grew by 8.3% YoY in Q1, doubling the growth rate of the previous year. Three reasons could underpin this rise in industrial demand and inventory stockpiling: a) Companies stocked up in anticipation of higher commodity prices. b) Investment in the first year of the 15th Five-Year Plan might experience a significant recovery. c) Domestic AI development led to semiconductor and computer imports exceeding exports by USD 54 billion in the first four months.

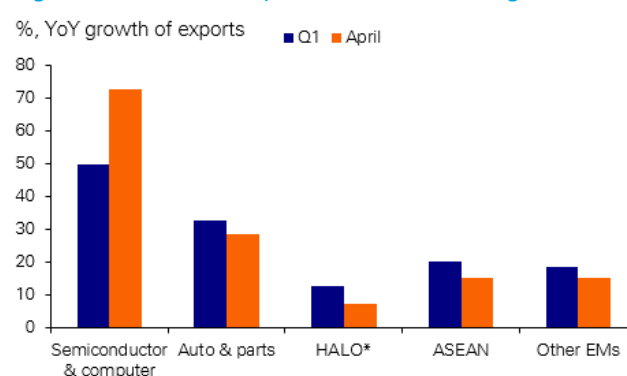


Figure 1: China' trade momentum continues in April



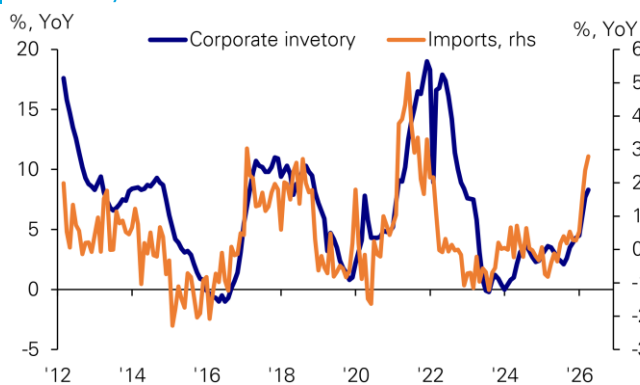
Source: Deutsche Bank Research, Haver Analytics

Figure 2: "AHEAD" exports remained strong



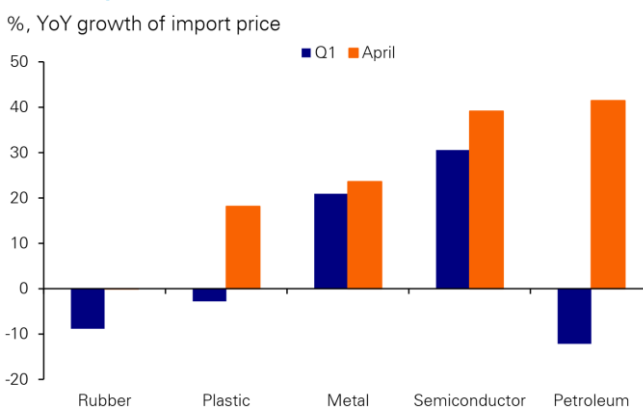
Source: Deutsche Bank Research, Wind. * As April data has not been fully disclosed yet, 'HALO' here only includes certain machinery and metals

Figure 3: China industrial corporates are building up inventory



Source: Deutsche Bank Research, Haver Analytics

Figure 4: Import-price growth in April broadly exceeded that of Q1



Source: Deutsche Bank Research, CEIC



Appendix 1

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